

Phishing refers to online fraud in the form of fake emails that appear to be sent by legitimate organizations (for example, a bank, a public authority, or an online shopping website), which prompt the recipient to share personal, financial, or security information. In this way, fraudsters gain access to usernames, passwords, or credit card information. Such emails often request that you download an attached document or click on a link. Given the frequency of online fraud, which is often successful for the attacker, we remind citizens to exercise caution when sending personal data via email or social media.

Do not enter your personal information, credit card details, do not send copies of identification cards, card PINs, CVC codes from cards (the last three digits on the back of the card), nor codes generated by mobile banking. Institutions such as banks and public authorities will not ask you to provide personal information via email. Also, keep in mind that to make a payment to an account, only the IBAN/account number and the name and surname of the account holder are required, not the details from your card (card number, expiration date, and CVC code)!

Below, we present the most common examples of phishing fraud, how to recognize them, and how to act if you receive a phishing email. However, the pattern of such messages is mostly the same: attackers use a similar email domain as the organization they are impersonating, call for urgent/quick action, messages often contain grammatical and spelling errors, and request certain personal information, most commonly asking for the entry of your card details. Therefore, if you do not want to be a victim of fraud, check whether the sender's email address matches the official email address of the institution, do not open links and attachments from suspicious senders, and under no circumstances enter and send your personal data (including card details)!

If you become a victim of fraud, immediately notify the Ministry of the Interior of the Republic of Croatia!

EXAMPLE 1. FAKE EMAILS FROM THE BANK

You are a user of x bank and as their client, you receive updates from the bank, information about their products or services to your email address. One day, you received an email from the bank asking you to click on a link to:

- confirm your bank account details;
- update the mobile banking application;
- confirm a recently completed transaction;
- verify your identity to regain access to your account after unauthorized access by a third party (your account has been blocked due to suspicion that someone has been using your card without authorization).

These are just some examples of phishing that fraudsters use banks to gain financial benefits and your personal data.

How to recognize fraud?

Although the sender's name is that of the bank and you did not suspect it at first, check the sender's email address. If it does not match the official email address (domain) of your bank, delete the email immediately. For example, you are a client of x bank which has the official domain @xbanka.hr, and you received an email from a sender whose domain is, for example: @x-banka.com, @xbanka.eu, @hr-xbanka.com, @m-xbanka.com, it is a fraud.

Check the subject of the email as it often states IMPORTANT, URGENT. Attackers emphasize urgency or importance in the subject line of the email to prompt you to react.

Check the content and accuracy of the spelling and grammar of the email. Such messages often start with a generic greeting (e.g., dear customer, dear client, esteemed client, etc.), contain grammatical and spelling errors, and the content of the email always calls for urgent (quick) action (e.g., click to avoid losing your account, confirm within 24 hours, etc.).

If you received a link or a button that you must click to confirm your identity or update the application, it is very likely a fraud. If you are unsure, you can always contact the bank, but do not click!

Check the link in the email to see where it leads and whether it matches the official domain by hovering over the link, but do not click. Remember, attackers often use addresses that are similar to the official addresses of the bank (e.g., x-banka.com, hr-xbanka.com, etc.), so examine the address carefully.

The attachment sent by the attackers is malicious software, and by downloading such an attachment, sensitive, personal, financial, and similar data is often collected. Therefore, do not download them if you are not sure about the sender!

If you receive a suspicious email, follow the steps outlined and do not click on links, do not download attachments, and do not respond to such messages. Report it to the bank and delete the email! Remember, the bank will not send you an email containing a link to confirm your bank account details, will not ask you for card details, PINs, passwords, codes from m-tokens, or ask you to confirm a recently completed transaction via email or link. The bank will not ask you to provide personal information via email, but will ask you to come in person to the branch.

Example of a phishing email (e.g., you are a client of x bank whose official domain is @xbanka.hr):

EXAMPLE 2. FAKE EMAILS FROM PUBLIC AUTHORITIES

Nowadays, attackers increasingly present themselves as public authorities, such as:

- An email from the Tax Administration informing you that your tax refund has been approved, and in order for it to be paid out, you need to click on a link or scan a QR code.
- An email from the Tax Administration requesting payment of taxes, and in order to make the payment, you need to click on a link or scan a QR code.
- An email from public authorities (for example, HZZO, the Ministry, etc.) informing you that you are entitled to receive assistance or reimbursement of expenses in a certain amount, and in order for it to be paid out, you need to click on a link or scan a QR code.
- An email from the Police Administration informing you that you have been accused of various criminal offenses and that you must submit your statement regarding the criminal act within a specified time frame.

How to recognize a scam?

- Be sure that public authorities will not ask you for credit card information.
- Check the sender's email address; if it does not match the official email address (domain) of the public authority, it is a scam.
- Pay attention to grammatical and spelling errors; such messages and letters are often full of mistakes.
- You are urged to react urgently (within 24 to 72 hours) – click on the link, scan the code, or provide a statement regarding the criminal act within a specified time frame.
- Scanning QR codes or accessing the link opens a fake website that looks like the real one – pay attention to the URL!

If you receive a suspicious email, follow the steps outlined and do not click on links, do not scan QR codes, do not download attachments, and do not respond to such messages!

Examples of phishing emails:

Source of the photo: cert.hr

Source of the photo: MUP RH

EXAMPLE 3. BUYING AND SELLING THROUGH ONLINE CLASSIFIEDS

You have advertised a mobile phone for sale through an online classifieds site or social media, and you were soon contacted by a potential buyer via message. In the message, they state that they are interested in purchasing and ask if the item is still available. You are happy to have found a buyer and that you will make a profit, but first, check if the potential buyer is indeed a buyer or is trying to obtain your personal and financial information.

Frauds that occur when buying or selling an item advertised through online classifieds are very common, as attackers monitor the ads that are posted and also post fake ads to gain financial benefit. Here is an overview of how to recognize that it is a scam.

How to recognize a scam?

- After the attacker confirms that they will buy the item, they will very likely say that they will immediately transfer the funds and arrange for delivery. You will notice that they did not ask you for payment details (name and surname, IBAN of the account).
- Then they will provide you with a link and ask you to click on it and enter the requested information to ensure the delivery of the item to their address and the receipt of funds to your account. A fake website that looks like a delivery service or classifieds site will likely open.
- By opening the link, you will notice that you are asked to enter credit card information. Keep in mind that to transfer funds to an account, only the name and surname of the account holder and the IBAN of the account are needed. If you notice that someone is asking you for card details, it is a scam! Do not enter the information!
- The attacker will insist that you fill in the information via the link because that is the only way the "transferred" funds can reach your account.
- If you notice such a message, block the number, do not open links, and do not enter your information!!
- If you are buying through online classifieds, do not open links and do not enter card details!
- Remember, to transfer funds to an individual's account, the only information needed is the name and surname of the account holder and the IBAN of the account. If the other party asks you to enter card details to transfer funds to you, it is a scam!

EXAMPLE 4. FAKE EMAIL OR SMS FROM A COURIER AND DELIVERY SERVICE

Attackers often use courier services to obtain personal data and financial benefits. Therefore, below are several examples of fake messages in which the attacker wants to prompt you to send money and leave your personal information:

- An email informing you that a package is waiting for delivery, and in order for it to be delivered, you need to pay a delivery fee of a few cents via the link. By clicking on the link, a fake delivery service page will open, and it will often state that delivery is not possible and that a fee must be paid; otherwise, the shipment will be returned to the sender.
- An email informing you that your package will be returned to the sender if you do not pick it up, and you are asked to click on the link for more information. By clicking on the link, a fake delivery service page will open, and it will state that...

It is necessary to pay the postage fee within a specified time frame; otherwise, the shipment will be returned to the sender. An email informing you that your package cannot be delivered until customs duties and/or VAT are paid by clicking on the link. By clicking on the link, a fake page of the delivery service will open, stating that it is necessary to pay a fee in order to receive your shipment.

How to recognize a scam?

Check the sender; if it does not match the official email address (domain) of the delivery service, it is a scam. If you have received a link, check if it matches the official website address. Always check the link first by hovering over it with your mouse, and it should be displayed, but do not click. Additionally, you can check the address by right-clicking to copy the link address into, for example, Word, and then compare the address with the official address. By opening the link, a fake website of the delivery service will most often open; check the URL address! If you are asked to enter credit card information, do not enter the information, close the page, and delete the email or SMS.

Protect your personal data and do not share it lightly!